

Comradeship and Other Poems

By

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Preface:

Comradeship and other poems are a few of poems in a collection; titled: "Izon Ekpekpe" written by John Suofe. These poems decry both the political, social, and economic plights of the "crying minority babies" of the Niger Delta Region in the Nigerian Nation State, particularly, the IZONS. Ekpekpe is the traditional IZON word for a gong used by a town crier to disseminate information in the olden days. The poems contained provides a food-for-thought for the politically, socially and economically oppressed Niger Deltans to think deep, unite and chart a common course for their progress in the Nigerian polity.

In order words, the poems are aimed at advocating for both political and social equality in the socio-political engineering of the Nation's politics. For it is perceived that, there is social, political inequality, greediness, betrayal and leadership failure in Nation's polity. For instance; poems like 'Today for us' deals directly with social/political inequality encountered by the Niger Delta people since inception of Nigeria. While, "Comradeship 1&11" and "Which is Stronger" like Niyi Osundare's *The Leader and the Led* satirizes the corruption, despotism, betrayal, greed, biasness, wickedness and leadership failure in the political class. Then, of course, "Where I come from" and "Bayelsa" speaks of ethnic nationality and identity/pride. And finally, "Woyengi 1&11" are an invocation of indigenous spirituality for hope. Thus, like Christopher Okigbo and Kwesi Brew's poems *Heavensgate, A plea for Mercy* Woyengi 1&11 invokes, prayers to Woyengi (God) she who owns the world for deliverance from a bad governance by the leaders. It is a religious chant having a strong element of religious ritual purely of Christianity. Thus, like Osundare, the poet condemns leaders who enrich themselves at the expense of the majority masses and portrays the devastating social consequences of their actions. In "Woyengi" 1&11, the poet like Okigbo, Osundare, and Kwesi Brew intertwine political and social commentary with deep reverence for God.

Poems of politics, betrayal, greediness, wickedness and leadership failure:

COMRADESHIP... John Suofe.

I too, am a comrade.
With clenched fist and arms
Pitched to the Tents
I too sing the National Anthem
That translates your manifesto theme

Sugar-coated and convincing you tongue-lashed
With promises brimming
But today, that theme song jettisoned
And a new unfriendly one emerged
Succor will not come
Even to feed from the crumbs
Is a tug of war.

What kind of world is this?
Or is it the political language that is standardized?
How then, we talk about development and unity?
Cannot be achieved, because, its maggot infested,
To the bone marrows
As far as this trend continues,
An attempt will be a mere foolery,
For, political register forbids it.

COMRADESHIP II... by John Suofe.

And now you have returned,
Looking melancholy
With huge debts covering your face
What about your Swiss Accounts?
Your fleet of cars and many mansions
What about those new friends
That carved the new theme song for you
When you betrayed?

We were comrades,
Too tight for the water to lick

Loyal and dedicated to your course
And so put a grim struggle,
With hard work, prayers and fasting,
Without recourse to any sentiments,
To see you rise on top.
Thinking, old friends will be remembered.
Rather, family and aliens in our long-nursed project surfaced.

Displacing the old
Which you embraced
Appointments and contracts,
Jobs and Finances,
You give,
All to these new converts.
Then, why stand here with sober eyes,
Looking this way and that
In no particular direction

Is it an apology you seek for another term?
Or a caricature of your old friends you impoverished?
Go! Integrity leader, go
No one's destiny is in your hands,
So, go and slug it out with your gold-diggers.
And continue your merriment.
The lord is our strength.

TODAY FOR US ... by John Suofe (2011)
Today, for us Mr. President
Nigeria, a country existed over
Fifty years after Independence.
But, whose ruler ship,
A monopoly of the Northern Caliphate
Has today shifted stand.
And flown to your grip,
Our grip with ease.

Thanks to Nature, whose hand
Change is permanent.

So, now Mr. President, what is on your mind?
Of all our sufferings,
Of all the intimidations,
The dehumanization
Politically, socially and economically.
Orchestrated by these seeming dreaming
Permanent occupants of the Nation's top-most Chair

Are you going to let go this past
And will not make amend?
Or do you not like your tribes man?
If no, then, why tarry?
Or do you lack consciousness of the position you occupy?
Or is it one of consideration, politicking
Or intellectual and administrative incapability
Or swayed by the twisting applauds?

Remember, your tribe existed in same day
With those that ruler ship spoon was born along with.
Forty-nine years and over, they ruled
With no recourse to your tribe's existence
But, today, you occupy this fragile, pregnant
But succulent, commanding and unimaginable seat
Made possible by God.

Thus, Ebele, I urge you.
March not the veiled ground.
For, it has many holes
And will gulp you.

Bank not on the zeal of the people
Their hearts are deleterious.
Don't lick the soup, because it's delicious.
Mind not the feigned loyalty of the people.
All these are only but a ploy to give
You confidence and security
But, the same security
Gives place for conspiracy.

In this world, kit and kin
Rejoice at their brother's success.
Remember, when even your hen
Is in duel with another and yours defeated
Dejection is your day.

We are happy and behind you.
Therefore, think deeper and
Effect radical development in your region, your tribe
These should sound most high to you.
Never think of tomorrow, because, it is pregnant
And none knows what child it will bring forth.
Death, war, division or even coup de` tat
Any one is possible
For those who claim ownership of our great country
Never envisaged Izon leadership
And so deems it a taboo.
Thus, angry and machinations they conceive.

Therefore, I implore you
Identify with your kits and kin
Your tribe, your region
Whose economy, politics and social status
Deliberately dehumanized.

For today is for us.
Is not by your power or anyone's
But, God almighty whose creation
Makes everyone exist
Others were there, and benefits they count.
The Hausas, Yorubas and the Igbos
Who claims major ownership of
The geographical enclave of the Nigerian Nation State
Still desires permanent occupation of this seat
Especially, the Hausas
Therefore, Jonathan, rise up
And consider your oppressed brothers
Who are yelling for a swift change

For the battle is hard.
But, we are solidly behind you
Seek advice, if you encounter difficulty
From the tribe's Nationalists.
It is Izons day, it is Niger Delta's government.
And your ascendancy is worth Izons
And the Region's contribution to our Nation's economy.

Therefore, none will dare to spoil it.
For, we have never spoilt any.
But, if the former prevails,
Then, it leaves no option for the
Crying minority babies to continue their course

So, Mr. President, act and act now.
For, today is for us.

WHICH IS STRONGER... by John Suofe.
Which is stronger?
Blood or political tie
Some says, it is political tie
While others say, it is blood.

I think, I must succumb to the latter.
For I have seen it practiced.
Political leaders, in spite of loyalty and dedication,
The political tie is a mere pulley
To assist the leader rise to top
And when the chips are down
Relations will always bond together.
No manner of tent pitched.

That is why, they say
Blood is thicker than water.
And so, Blood is stronger.
Remember this and take caution,
In the support of your leader
Because, when arrived,

Succor will evade you.
At your expense, his blood
Would he satisfy
Then, lies and excuses he
Will tell to make foolery of you
Therefore, follower you must be wise
To recognize these.

Poems of Ethnic identity and pride
WHERE I COME FROM...John Suofe.

Where I come from
Is the tribe of the Izons
A people of great birth
Whose nature dyed black

Geographically situated
And scattered around
The swamps of the delta region
With rich natural resources
Characterized by truth, magnanimity,
Humility and love in her infancy,

Has now reversed trait to
Insincerity, greed, wickedness, impunity and pride
So, in her new tenets
The land suffers,
Suffers from disunity, underdevelopment and detest.

Forgetting that this country they exist
Is progressively chaotic
And they are politically castrated.
Reduced to shreds of dry fiber
Economically ruined and socially neglected

Their traditional family life drifts altered.
And women enrolled into prostitution
Potential men graduating into violent criminals or dupes

Then, children in obscurity and oblivion

Their perpetrators are the ruling cabal.
While their land is the economic resources
And themselves- the human resources
But their latter embraced friend
Rock them out.

Because, distrust is born
So, disgruntlement and grumble takes precedence.

My brothers! What is happening to you?
A world where inhabitants seek for correction
And right path to recognition.
You are here encapsulating in unnecessary competition.
And dwindling your progress

You who had hoe that can perform
Great deeds on the dung hill
For your growth and survival
Sits here plotting each other's downfall

And when it succeeds
Like the earthworm, you crawl proudly.

Do you forget that
If the fowl had a hoe
It would have performed much well in the dung hill

So, Brothers! Let us turn.
Turn from our new trait to the old
Till our soil well
And carve our empire of glory.

BAYELSA... by John Suofe.
Naturally and geographically situated

In the Creeks of the Delta Region
Economically significant in the Nigerian Nation State
Whose creation informed of improved
Life of the socially, economically and politically oppressed Izons

But, almost at a decade and half
With copious natural resources and manpower,
To avalanche of both military and political succession
Beginning from 1996 to date,

Still trapped in leadership competence, and Citizenry development
Perhaps, the beautiful ones have not
Yet arrived to broke the unintended
Jinx bedeviling the administration of the Embryo State.
So, I ask
What are the creators of such a philanthropic ideal
Doing to their children?
Or do they not hear their cries?

Boro! The common man epic hero (Revolutionary)
Who gave his life yesterday for our today
Whose legacy is what Izons rejoice
Without sincere acknowledgment

Where are you?
Can good leadership not crop up,
Out of your spiritual intervention?
Or has your spirit become so womanish in death?
That, you cannot gesture any direction
Or is it the spectacular chains that are
Fettered around your rectangular tomb,
That keeps you mealy-mouthed and action less?

If so, then, what about your brother Dan Etete
The one who's Bayelsa is synonymous with.
Alive, but paying deaf ears

What then, informed his creation?

Live us to suffer in the hands of unfriendly brothers.
I know, we have a problem-Disunity.
That is it.
But wake up Brothers, wake up,
Provide succor and lead your Kinsmen
To your idealized life.

Poems of spirituality, reverence and hope

Woyengi ... by John Suofe.
Before you, Woyengi,
 helpless we stand,
Before your Eminent presence,
 an impoverished people.
The only vineyard, encroached inhumanely,
 by the King.
A lottery it becomes.
Grabbed with skepticism,
What the King may policy each dying day.
We do not know
So, on our feet, have we surrendered.
Asking for Mercy and Compassion.
Out of the depth, our cry,
 give ear and hearken.
Under your power, wait we in tears,
And beggarly doth stretch out our hands
Prisoners for a Saving Grace.

Woyengi 11
All hail the King
Administrative acumen, he lacks.
Greed and villainy, he unleash.
Dry, dry the land.
Fertility losing it's grip.
Coercing the City into an emergency
 Agribusiness and Commercial hub.
Decent women enrolling into prostitution.
And virtuous and vibrant men,
 Turning into violent dupes and criminals.

Children, in obscurity and oblivion.
What horrors of draconian,
Have we not encountered?
But, Woyengi- she who owns the world,
Will answer someday.
That day,
The City will match-flare in Wind's breath.
Joyous and convenience,
Inviting sudden gatherings,
And sudden gatherings
Transiting into songs and dances.
In acknowledgment of freedom.
All in praise of Woyengi.

Afterword

The poems contained here generally have a revolutionary or protest approach, by challenging the rulers in a comprehensive manner and engaging for the ruled. Thus, the poet's vision is to advocate for equality, focusing on issues like politics, where betrayal, greed, wickedness and leadership failure takes precedence, and social/economic injustice and the struggle of the oppressed. However, the poems are in three categories; titled; Poems of politics and betrayal, ethnic identity and pride and spirituality and hope. For instance; in the first category, throughout the poems, we witness how the poet registered his displeasure with heavy sense of anger crowned with the desire to right the wrongs meted to his tribes despite her rich natural resources which accounts for 65% of the nation's economy. While in the second, tagged as; Ethnic identity and pride; the poet here shows off of his identity as an Izon man to the world and that he is proud of it. Lastly, the third category which is titled: Spirituality and hope. Here the poet deals with speculative poems that revolves around the themes of supplication rendered to "Woyengi" (God), the creator of the world. Throughout these poems, we witness how the poet offered solicitations to the Supreme being with heavy sense of humility crowned with the hope that she (God) would hearken to his pleas. The speculative approach of the poet towards to the delivery of these poems ensured that the existence and the essence of God (Woyengi) was heavily felt and alive throughout the lines of the poems.

John Suofe

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